

Species: Purple Finch (Vernacular Name) Carpodacus purpureus (Scientific Name-use binomial)

Date(s): 18 October 1976 Time Bird Seen: 0845 to 0850

Locality: Boulder Creek at Ball Brothers

Nearest Town: Boulder County: Boulder

Other observers who independently identified this bird:

NAME	ADDRESS	TELEPHONE
Steve Larson		

Optical Equipment: 10x50 binocs

If photographed, type of equipment used: _____

Light Conditions: excellent, sunlit in AM sun; later also in shade

Distance from bird (how measured): 60 ft - guessed at height of trees

Number of Birds Seen: 2 Sex: ♂ Plumage: _____

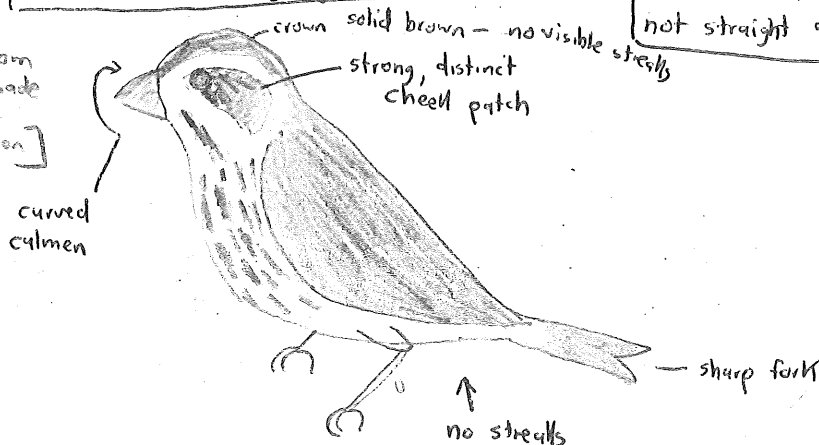
Describe the bird's overall behavior and demeanor:

Both birds were feeding in the treetops and sitting for several minutes at a time, virtually motionless. Occasionally, they would move from one tree to another.

Describe in great detail the bird's size, overall shape, plumage and color-pattern. Include details on shape of bill, wings and tail. Give particular emphasis to the marks you used to identify the bird. Reference to its resemblance in field guide descriptions is not enough. Describe what you actually saw in the field:

They were the same size and shape as House Finches, perhaps a bit chunkier; tail was sharply forked, not with rounded lobes as in House Finch. They were heavily streaked on the breast and had a strong face pattern (see drawing). Overall coloration was dark brown, darker brown than either Cassin's or House Finch. Upperparts were dark brown with streaks on back barely evident. ^{Lower} Belly and undertail coverts were whitish without any streaks - the lack of streaks on the undertail coverts was extremely obvious from our vantage point from below. The culmen was clearly seen to be curved, not straight as in Cassin's.

[Inferred from drawing made just after observation]



Describe the bird's song or call, if heard, including method of delivery, i.e., from perch, in flight, etc: I found these birds by noting the very distinctive flight notes — a soft, hollow "pic" note which I know very well from extensive experience in California and which is diagnostic for this species. Cassin's Finch call notes are very different. Anyone who doesn't believe these two species can be told apart by call notes is either deaf or has no experience in the field with these birds. For Coloradans who have payed any attention at all to call notes of Cassin's Finches, picking out Purple notes as something very different from anything given by Cassin's is easy. Describe the habitat in which you observed this bird:

Willow riparian — canopy

How were similarly appearing species eliminated?

Cassin's Finch (♀)

1. call notes of this species are richer and sweeter, usually consisting of 2-3 notes
2. culmen of Cassin's Finch is straight, not distinctly curved, and bill is longer — not "parrot-shaped" as in Purple and House Finches
3. cheek patch of Cassin's Finch is much less sharply defined
4. undertail coverts of Cassin's Finch are prominently streaked, and this is readily visible in the field, especially from below (the way we saw these birds)
5. Cassin's Finch is grayer overall — not so dark brown
6. Cassin's Finch has narrower, sharper streaks on breast

House Finch (♀)

1. lacks prominent face pattern
2. call notes very different
3. slimmer body shape
4. tail not sharply forked
5. overall much grayer

Prior experience with this and similarly appearing species:

In Northern California, I hear Purple Finches almost daily and I'm extremely familiar with their call notes. I also had them coming to my feeder for two school-years in Mass. I am not as familiar with Cassin's Finches but I've still seen and heard them many times. In March I studied a flock of Cassin's near San Diego for 45 minutes with field identification in mind and during a recent 3-day weekend in Yosemite Nat. Park, Calif. I saw and heard 25+ Cassin's per day and again studied them closely with field identification in mind.

Books, illustrations and advice consulted and how did these influence this documentation?

I have looked at 200+ specimens of each species in the Museum of Vertebrate Zoology to verify consistencies of bill shapes and undertail covert streaking.

This report was written from notes made during _____ after ☒ observation; from memory _____

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